



Comprehensive Review of Faculty Survey Results for “COVID-19 Impacts on Higher Education”

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Executive Summary

In a recent survey of 122 faculty from universities across the United States, we asked participants about their experiences with transitioning to online learning in the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic.

Our survey participants had diverse levels of years in their field, experience in teaching online and hybrid courses, and approaches to teaching. In terms of technology use and support, respondents identified the tools they found most valuable and expressed overall satisfaction with IT support. However, they also called for more training and diverse technology options, as well as improved accessibility.

To improve the online learning experience, participants identified student engagement and institutional support as key issues to be addressed, while also highlighting accessibility and resource needs. Calling for more guidelines and support mechanisms for students and faculty, our respondents emphasized the “human side” of the learning experience. Respondents used diverse teaching approaches to navigate the Spring 2020 semester, acknowledging that they had been forced to make sizable adjustments to their instruction plans and outcomes. Looking forward, they planned for future online and hybrid courses and recommended more flexible, personalized approaches to course offerings.

Introduction

Our survey results compile faculty responses on diverse issues related to higher education experience in the COVID-19 pandemic. While speaking to the challenges and frustrations of the abrupt transition to online delivery in Spring 2020, respondents also had many ideas about how they and their institutions could strengthen their students' educational outcomes. Our analysis of this data considers the challenges and critiques offered by our respondents but focuses on the constructive suggestions participants offered on how to move forward in a situation that continues to present many challenges.

Methodology

From May to July 2020, just after the close of the Spring 2020 semester, our survey was opened and faculty members invited across social media and other platforms to participate. The survey consisted of 52 questions based around 5 main topics--demographics, online learning experience, teaching methods, technology support, and technology use, and included single answer, multiple answer, and free text questions related to these topics. After we drafted the initial questions, they were reviewed and revised by several higher education faculty before publication to ensure that our questions spoke accurately to faculty experiences.

Our goal for this survey was to gain insights from higher education faculty on their instruction experience in the midst of the COVID-19 pandemic. To understand the needs of faculty and higher education as a whole in this challenging situation, we asked respondents questions about their approach to online instruction, their experience with technology support and tools, their interactions with their students, and their expectations and suggestions for the future.

In analyzing our results, we organized our feedback according to our main survey topics, taking into account the quantitative feedback from multiple choice questions and the qualitative feedback from free text entries. Gathering data from Qualtrics analytics reporting and charting qualitative feedback according to our focal topics, we reported on the experiences, suggestions, and concerns of our 122 faculty respondents.

Some limitations of the study were issues with representation and difficulties in synthesizing qualitative data. According to our respondent demographics, we lacked good representation from the physical and mathematical sciences, as well as from smaller, non-doctoral institutions. In terms of qualitative data, we received a broad range of responses expressing many viewpoints, and our report's summary of common themes could not fully address all feedback.

Demographics

Our data showed that our 122 survey respondents tended to come from similar types of institutions but had diverse backgrounds, teaching experiences, and instructional needs.

Institutional Background

Over 76% of respondents were from doctoral universities, and 70% were from large institutions of more than 15,000.

Chart 1: Type of Institution

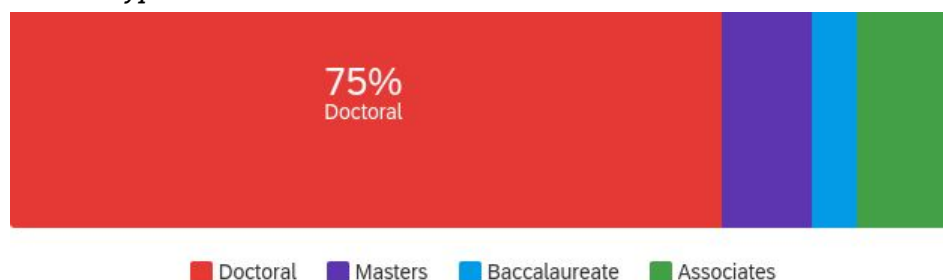
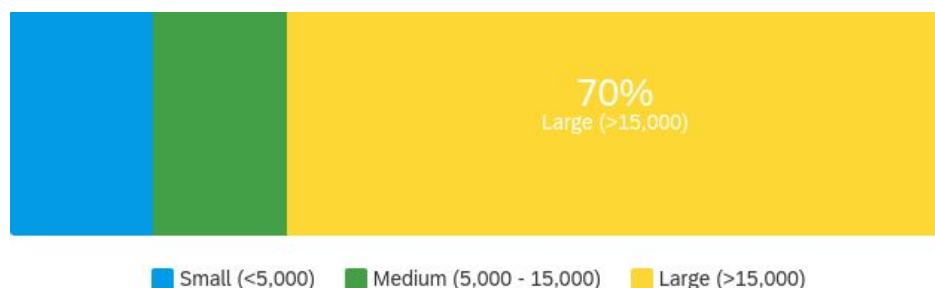


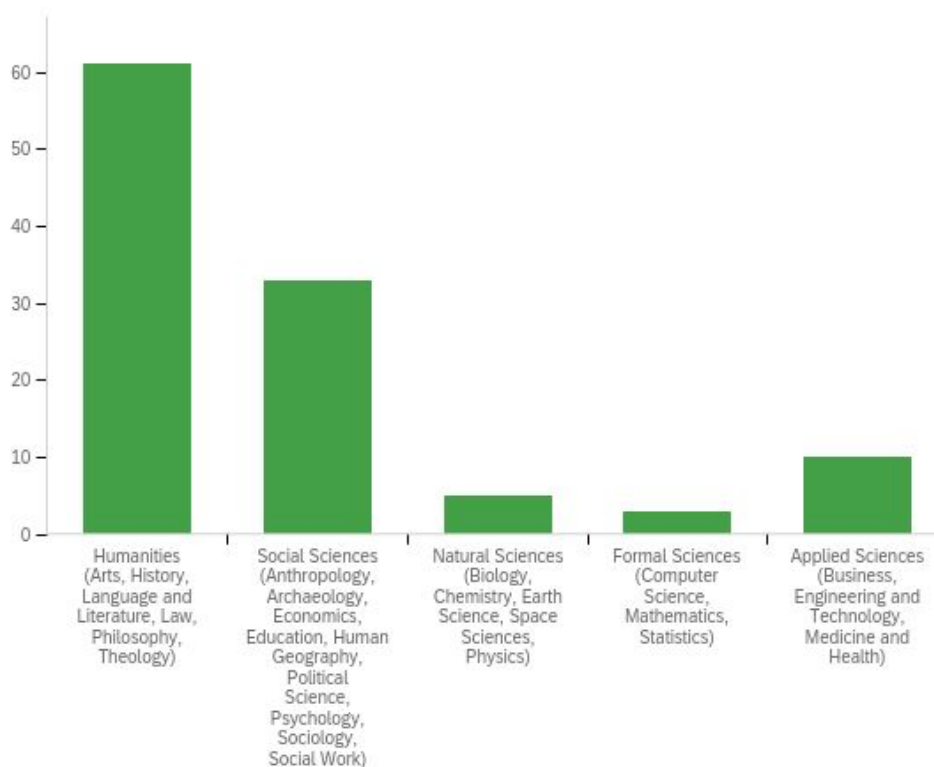
Chart 2: Size of Institution



Main Field of Instruction

Most respondents taught in the humanities, with social sciences as the next most common area of instruction.

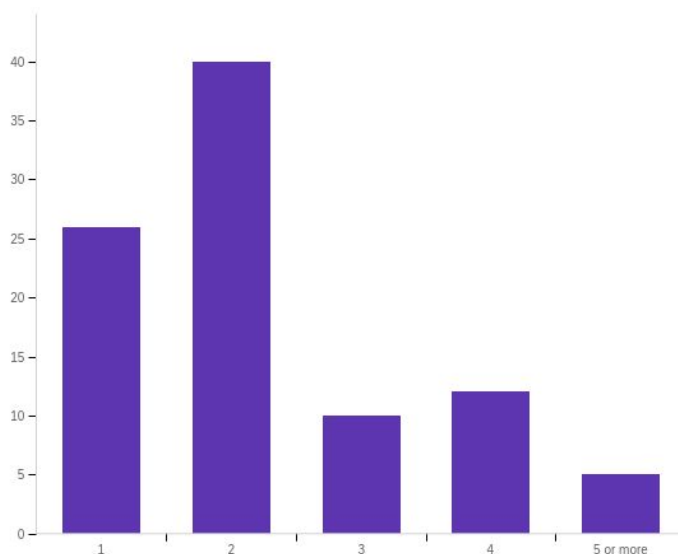
Chart 3: Area of Instruction



Teaching Loads for Spring 2020 Semester

On average, survey participants said that they had a teaching load of 1-2 courses in the Spring 2020 semester, with a significantly smaller number reporting that they had taught 3 or more courses during the semester.

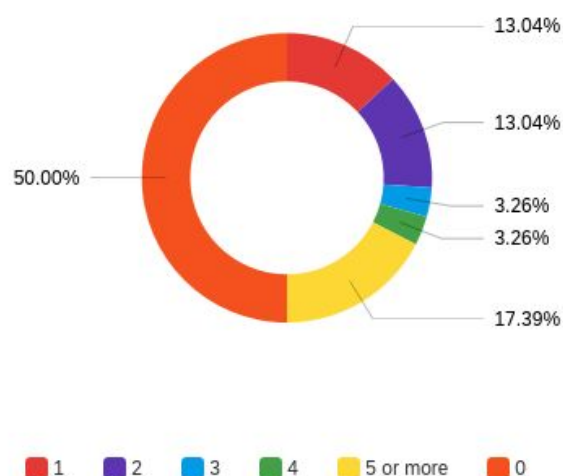
Chart 4: Semester Teaching Loads



Online and Hybrid Course Experience

In terms of experience, our data indicated that half of our participants had not taught online or hybrid courses before the Spring 2020 semester; the other half had varying levels of experience with delivering online instruction, ranging from 1 to 5+ hybrid or online courses.

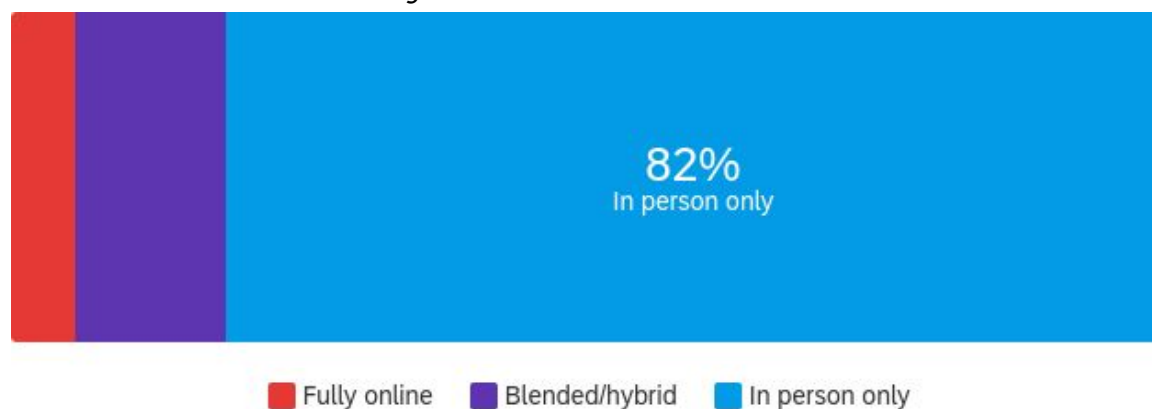
Chart 5: Online Experience



Experience Teaching in Different Formats

However, when asked their primary method of teaching prior to COVID-19, a sizable proportion of participants, 82%, said that they primarily taught in face-to-face classrooms.

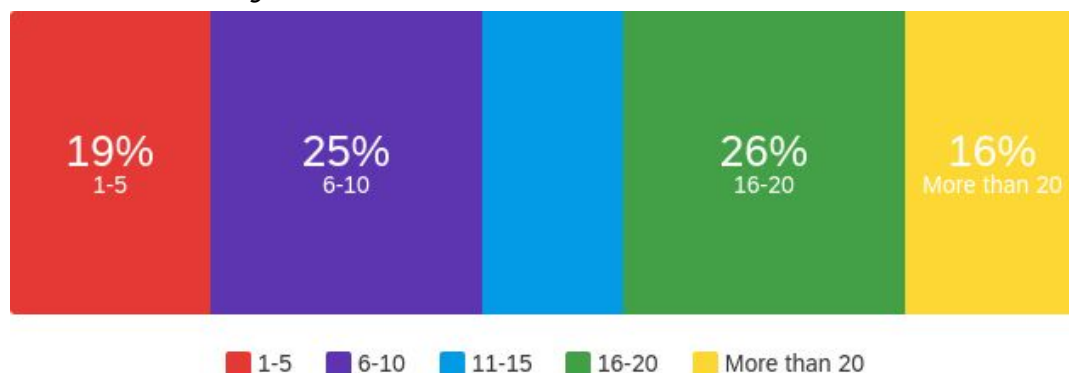
Chart 6: Most Common Teaching Formats



Level of Higher Education Experience

Participants had a broad range of years of experience in higher education, from between 1 and 5 to over 20 years in the field.

Chart 7: Years in Higher Education



Technological Use and Support

Overall, respondents were positive about the technology available to them during the admittedly challenging transition to online learning, but they also shared concerns and recommendations for improvement in the coming academic year.

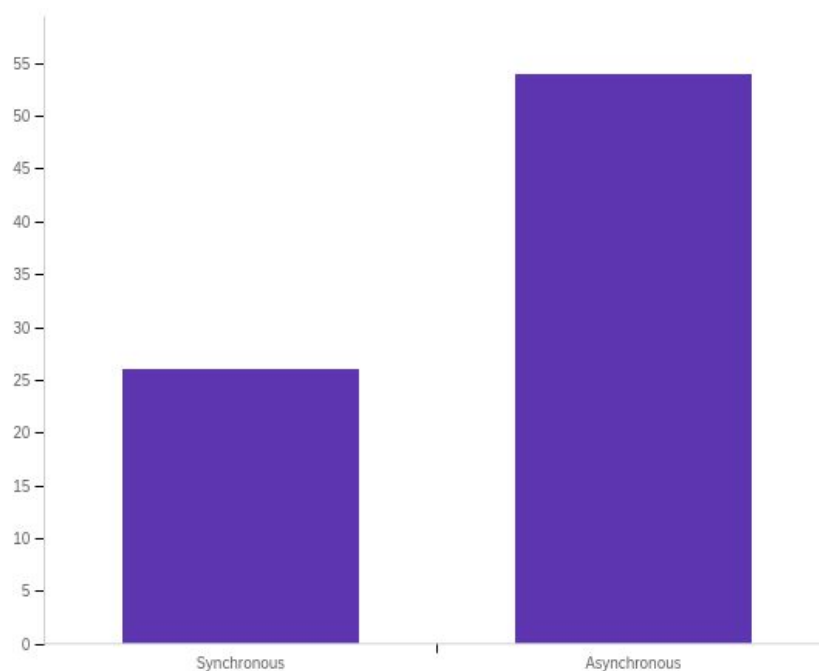
Technological Use

Technology use among respondents was relatively consistent, with the majority saying that they relied most on conferencing tools and emails for class meetings, office hours, general communication, and course content delivery.

Synchronous or Asynchronous Instruction

About 67% of respondents taught most of their classes asynchronously, and most relied on written discussion board posts or other written assignments to supplement learning content.

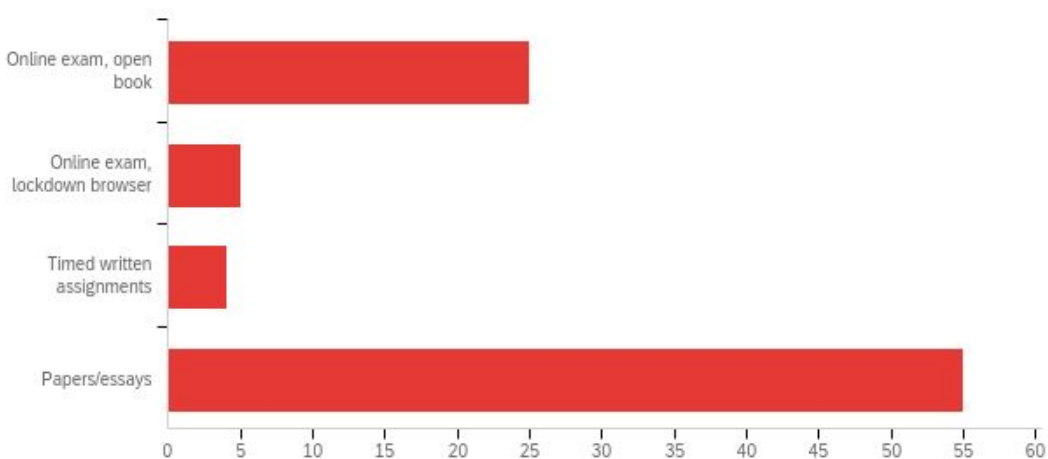
Chart 8: Synchronous or Asynchronous Format



Exam Delivery Approaches

For exams, survey participants relied largely on emails or their institution's Learning Management Systems, with papers and open book online exams being the most common evaluation methods.

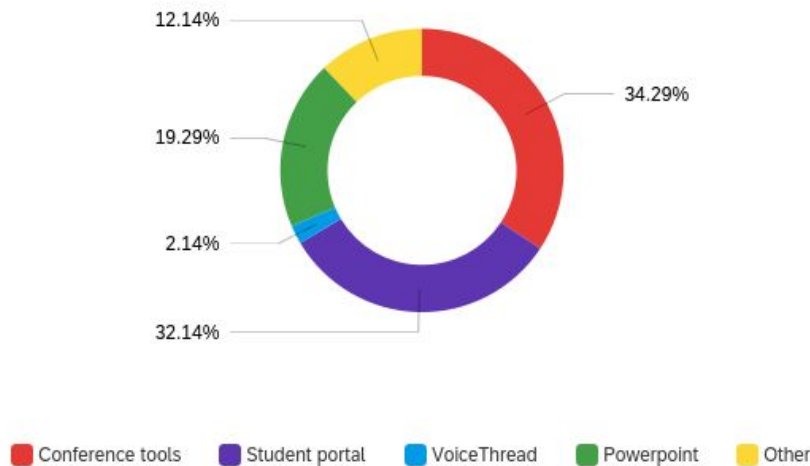
Chart 9: Exam Delivery



Most Valuable Online Instruction Tools

In terms of what tools were most valuable for online instruction, respondents pointed particularly to conference and student portal/LMS tools, among other tools.

Chart 10: Instruction Tools



Looking ahead, one respondent expressed the need for a better grasp of options and the ability to adapt, commenting, “I will need to learn more about all the different technologies that are available, so that I can adapt my pedagogy to provide the best outcome for my students.” With many noting their own struggles with both making their current tools meet their needs and simply having the knowledge they needed of platform and tool capabilities, faculty wanted more training and more options.

Technological Support

In general, respondents seemed to feel that they had the tools they needed for online learning and were satisfied with the IT support they received.

Satisfaction with Available IT Tools and Expertise

Among our survey participants, 88% felt that technological tools had been readily available to them, and 68% felt that technological expertise had been readily available.

Chart 11: Availability of Tools

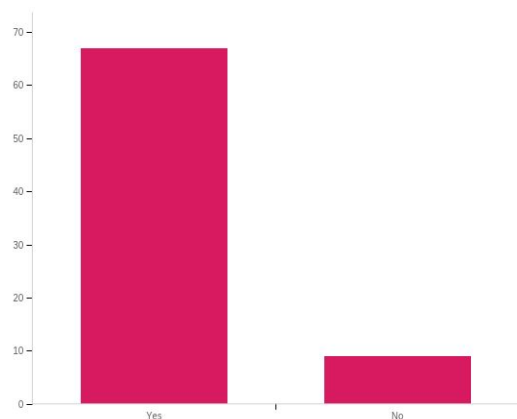
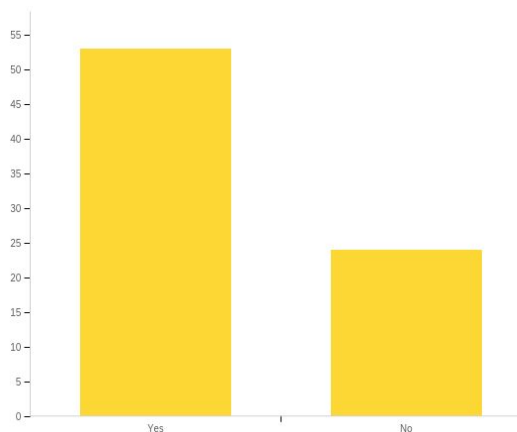


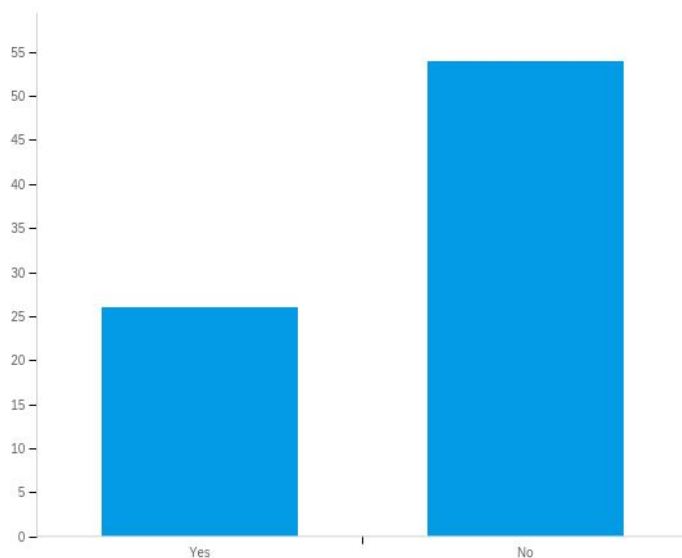
Chart 12: Availability of Expertise



Availability of Technology and Equipment

Similarly, 67% of participants said that they did not need to purchase any new technology post-transition.

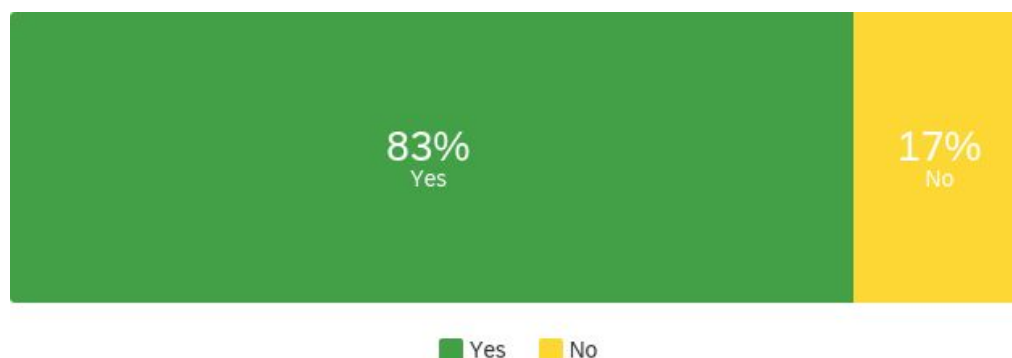
Chart 13: Purchase of New Technology



IT Support for Faculty

About half of our participants used their institution's IT support center, and the majority reported that their issue was resolved satisfactorily.

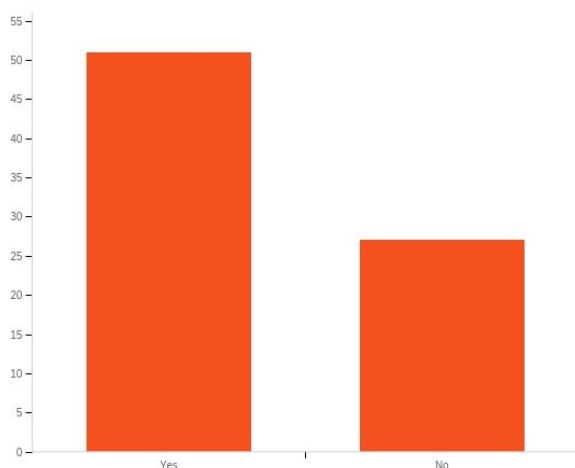
Chart 14: Faculty's IT Issue Resolved



IT Support for Students

Just over 66% also indicated that they had directed their students to technology support.

Chart 15: Directed Student(s) to IT Support



In their qualitative feedback, many survey participants expressed frustration with the limitations of the tools they used for the Spring 2020 semester and called for more diverse tools to be made available to faculty. Along with suggestions for more diverse options for class delivery and course material, many also addressed faculty's needs for basic technology like printers and ipads at home.

Accessibility and Resources

When asked to provide qualitative responses on the largest challenges for students' online learning, respondents expressed widespread concerns about lack of internet access and resources. "One of my students was unable to complete the semester because of internet access," one

respondent related. “Resources for this student--monetary or otherwise--may have helped them finish the semester.”

Respondents also commented on other resource-related issues that affected students, such as not having a printer. “Students have explicitly talked about how they can’t afford a printer but do better when engaging hard copy,” one survey participant related. To address these issues, many respondents suggested that institutions provide financial aid such as stipends or vouchers to assist students in accessing needed resources, such as Wifi hotspots for those with limited internet access.

Acknowledging that both faculty and students were faced with a very challenging learning situation, many pointed to the need to lower expectations, adjust course requirements, and find ways to work around connectivity, participation, and communication struggles. Faculty further suggested that institutions provide online access to mental health resources and other tools that would be harder for students to access off campus.

Online Learning Experience

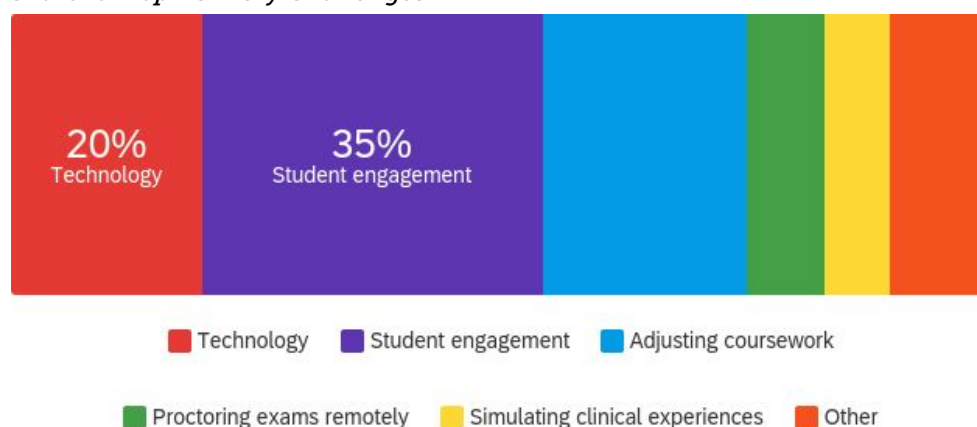
Considering the challenges that they faced in the Spring 2020 semester, respondents spoke to the key concerns of online learning and suggested ways to support students and faculty.

Student Engagement

Challenges of Online Instruction

The top online delivery challenge identified by participants, student engagement is a widespread issue in online learning experience, according to our survey participants.

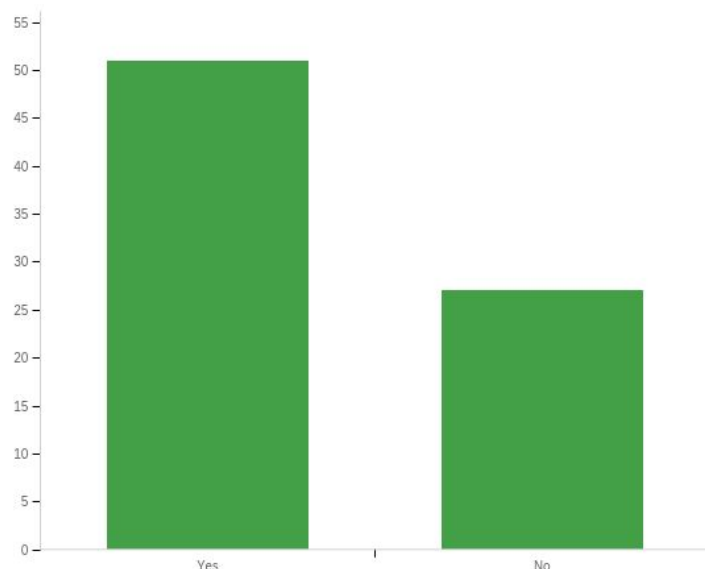
Chart 16: Top Delivery Challenges



Online Content Engagement

Over 65% of respondents felt that students were struggling to engage with course content, a similar 61% reported that they had lost contact with some students after transitioning to online learning. As one participant observed after emphasizing the need for consistent interaction between faculty and students, "It was too easy for the students to get lost and left behind."

Chart 17: Students Struggling to Engage with Online Content



To address this pressing issue, faculty had creative ideas about improving engagement opportunities and the overall learning environment. In particular, respondents' qualitative feedback emphasized the importance of strong communication between students and faculty, as well as students and peers. Many participants suggested incentives for faculty to be creative and consistent with online assignments and feedback, weekly check-ins, and regular correspondence with students to provide structure and accountability.

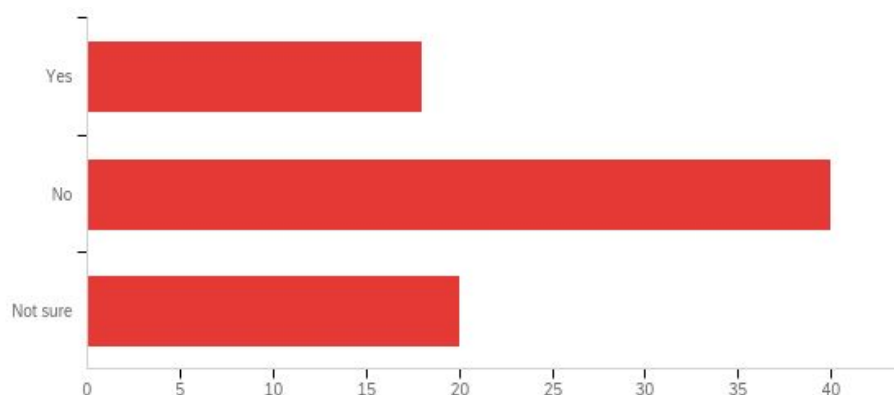
To maintain some sense of face-to-face interaction, respondents recommended incorporation of at least periodical synchronous meetings and video recordings. "One key," a respondent commented, "is making students know that there is a human on the other side of the class." Finding ways to integrate the human aspect of education into an online learning environment was for many faculty the crucial piece needed to foster strong student engagement.

Institutional Support

Institutional Templates and Guidelines

During the Spring 2020 semester, 51% of respondents indicated that they did not receive templates or specific guidelines for transitioning to online delivery from their respective institutions, and some were unsure if these resources had been available or not.

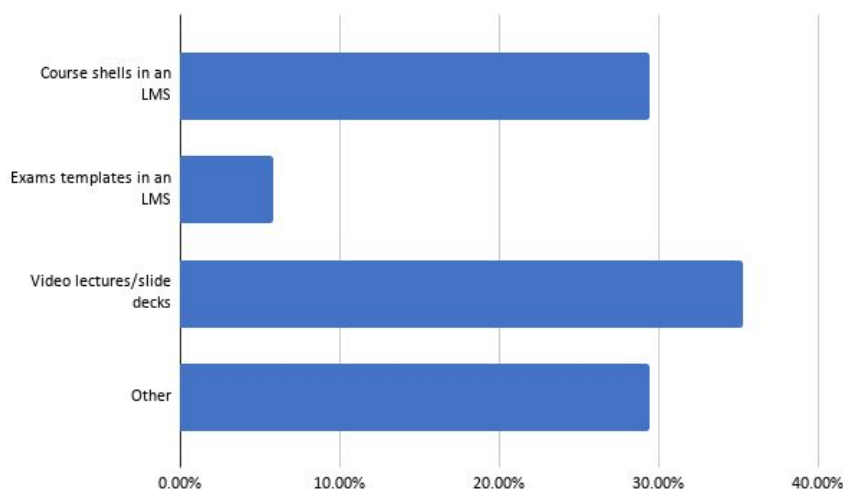
Chart 18: Participants Who Received Templates/Guidelines



Materials Provided by Institutions

Of the 23% of survey participants who did receive institutional guidelines, most received course shells or materials relating to video lectures and slide decks. In terms of course content, our survey participants had a broad range of teaching approaches and needs, relying on diverse content from online assignments to papers to research to lab work.

Chart 19: Templates and Guidelines Provided



In qualitative feedback, one respondent suggested credit incentives for faculty to develop innovative instructional approaches and foster creative problem solving. A number of others, meanwhile, called for institutions to offer more accountability and guidelines for instructors, observing that many faculty were largely on their own after the transition to online learning. In general, for instance, it seemed that respondents' institutions did not put any new mechanisms in place to evaluate instruction quality--most participants mentioned only standard Student Evaluations of Instruction (SEIs) as a form of evaluation.

In terms of the logistics of online instruction, many survey participants noted that more planning and preparation assistance for structuring courses, finding the right tools for instruction, and developing assignments would be invaluable. One respondent urged better support particularly for graduate teaching assistants and contract instructors, who might not have the same resources as other faculty. Finally, our participants suggested that a system be put in place to check in on not only students but also faculty as an added level of support.

Teaching Approaches

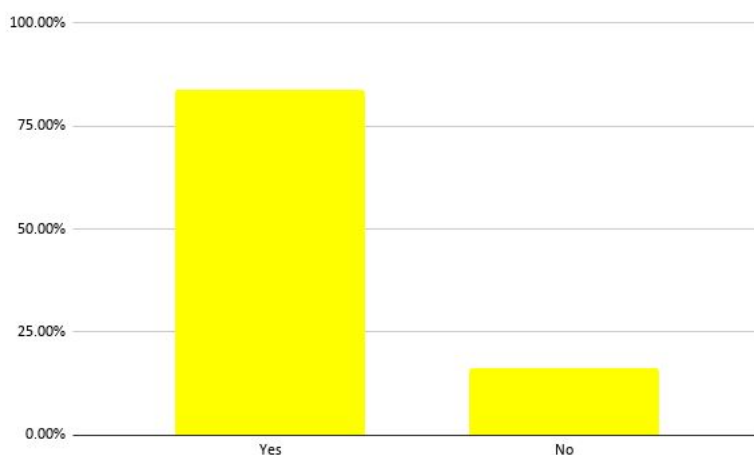
Discussing the significant adjustments they were compelled to make to their course material, assignments, and outcomes, our respondents reflected on their struggles and the changes they might make in the coming semesters, as well as speaking to the future of higher education teaching approaches.

Adjustments Required for Online Instruction

Course Adjustments for Online Learning

After transitioning to online delivery, most respondents said that they had to adjust course content, from removing final projects to replacing clinicals and hands-on lab work, and many changed their grading scale or intended course outcomes as well. Survey participants also said that they faced significant adjustments to a variety of non-teaching professional duties.

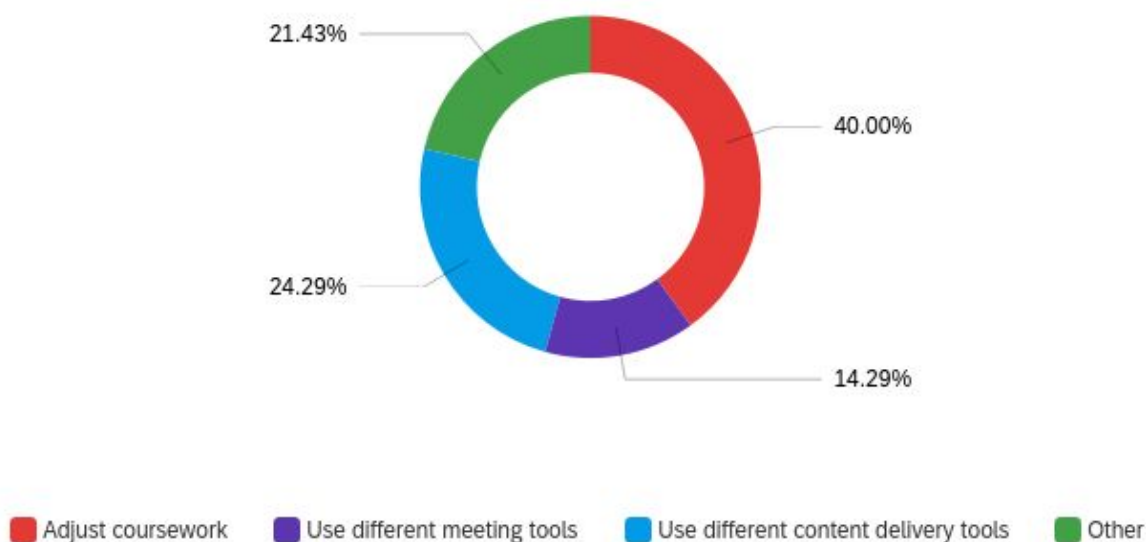
Chart 20: Participants Who Adjusted Syllabus



Changes Needed for Future Semesters

Were they in the same situation again, 39% of respondents said that they would make more adjustments to coursework, and 24% thought that using different tools would be helpful.

Chart 21: Future Adjustments



Respondents had practical, qualitative suggestions for approaching teaching within an online context, suggesting in particular that flexibility be a core piece of course design and that institutions provide more guidance and oversight to ensure consistency and coherence across each university. Many pointed out that students had unique needs, and offering a delivery format with both synchronous and asynchronous components could be valuable for reaching all students. As one respondent suggested, institutions could “designate or advertise whether they [courses] will be synchronous or asynchronous” on course descriptions.

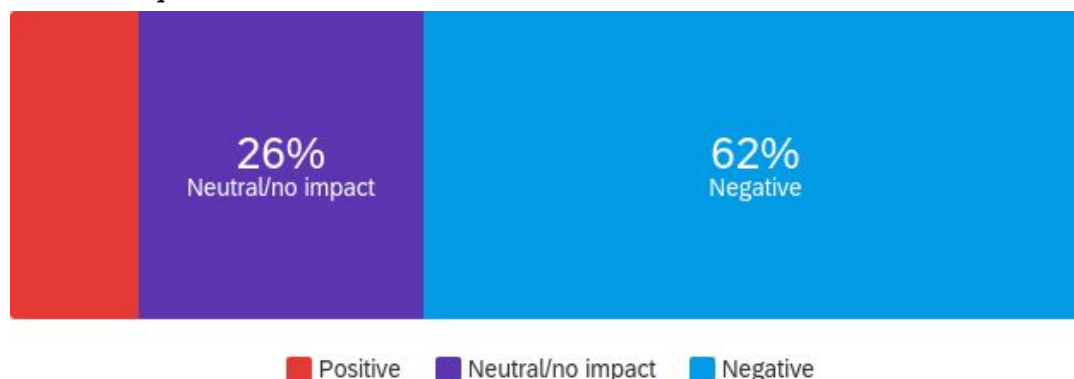
Smaller class sizes and reduced or adjusted assignments were also raised as ways to address the changing needs of the current situation; faculty often mentioned teaching through text and reducing courseloads as a whole, noting that students were often overwhelmed with work in the Spring 2020 semester.

Future of Online Instruction

Impact of Online Learning on Student Confidence

In terms of how distance learning will affect students, 61% of survey participants felt that students would likely have less confidence in online instruction as they acknowledged the challenges of the situation.

Chart 22: Impact on Student Confidence



At the same time, however, respondents' qualitative responses also offered some surprisingly positive perspectives on the situation. When asked what feedback they had received from their students, many reported that, while students tended to prefer in-person classes, they also were positive about how online learning was progressing, and they were encouraging of and grateful for their instructors' flexibility and availability in the midst of a truly challenging transition.

Current Goals for Planning Future Content

While faculty had mixed responses when asked about making definite plans for online learning in the future, 83% of respondents are considering blended teaching options in the future.

Chart 23: Current Goals

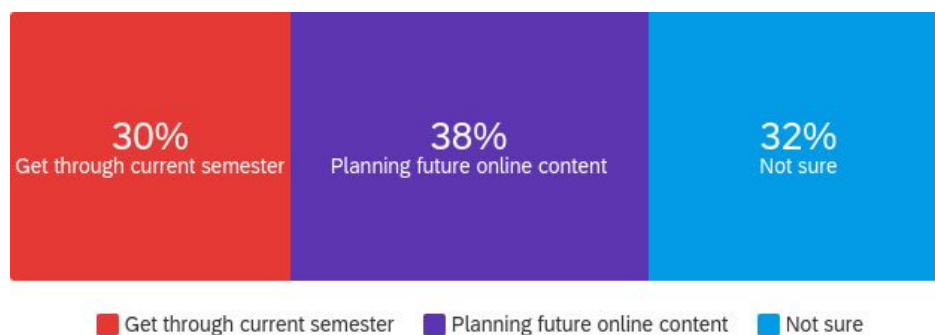


Chart 24: Considering Future Blended Teaching Options

